A dull gray light trickles in through the drawn blinds. The office is deserted, papers still scattered across the top of the desk. The front door lies west, and the file room lies east.

Sitting on the corner of the paper-strewn desk are a telephone and an answering machine.

Someone seems to have left a cup of coffee sitting out, half-finished and cold.

>examine desk
The top of the desk is littered with paperwork -- notes, messages, files, etc.; the way most desks tend to get at the end of a busy day. A telephone sits on one corner, next to a digital answering machine. There is a small drawer to one side.

>open drawer
It seems to be locked.

>examine answering machine
A simple answering machine, with a small display indicating messages received, a button labeled "PLAY", and a button labeled "DELETE".

>push play button
For a while there is nothing but a quiet hiss, followed by intermittent skirls of strange-sounding static. It sounds like one of those annoying glitches where the caller hangs up but the machine keeps recording anyway. Then, barely audible through the static, you detect what sounds like a human voice whispering a single word:

"Verlac."

The machine beeps.

A brief shudder ripples up your back. You remember now, "Verlac" is the name of this branch of Michael's family.

>east

File Room
Peering through the murk, you can make out the blocky outlines of filing cabinets lining the walls and a doorway to the west. A window high up on the south wall lets in a very faint illumination.

>look up verlac in filing cabinets
(in the filing cabinets)
Strange; the file on the Verlac property has been cleaned out. Title, deed, all the papers, all of it gone. There is, however, a set of keys tucked down in the hanging folder. You quickly pocket them.

Your score has just gone up by two points.

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